EK-02 Budget and Time Estimation: EVA-002, EVA-003, EST-001 to EST-006

Document ID: EK-02 | Category C: Evaluation knowledge base

1. Document metadata

Field	Value
Document ID	EK-02
Filename	EK-02_Budget_and_Time_Estimation.pdf
Category	C - Evaluation knowledge base
Version	1.0
Creation date	2026-10-14
Data status	Factual methodology (illustrative default parameters) with hypothetical worked examples | Illustrative estimates and factual estimation guidance (numbers are illustrative, not market prices)
Main topics	Budget compatibility; Hard budget limit; Preferred budget; Scope adjustment; Deadline compatibility; Feasibility; Capacity; Hard and soft deadlines; Web project estimation; Work breakdown structure; Angular; Spring Boot; PostgreSQL; Mobile estimation
Relevant skills and technologies	Budget analysis; Schedule analysis; Angular; Spring Boot; PostgreSQL; Docker; Unit testing; Flutter; Dart; Offline storage; Firebase push; Python; RAG pipeline; Vector search; scikit-learn; LLM evaluation; Kubernetes; CI/CD; Terraform; AWS; Monitoring; Project management
Relevant entity IDs	EVA-002, EVA-003, EST-001, EST-002, EST-003, EST-004, EST-005, EST-006, EVA-005, QUA-005, PRJ-001, PRJ-002, PRJ-006, FRE-006, PRJ-003, PRJ-004, FRE-004, PRJ-005, FRE-005

Purpose and scope: this PDF consolidates 8 source documents (EVA-002 to EST-006). Each source keeps its own ID in every section heading, so chunks stay attributable, for example [DOC:EVA-002/...].

2. Executive summary

Budget score is 100 up to the client's preferred maximum, falls linearly to 50 at the hard limit, and the proposal becomes ineligible above the hard limit. Documented exclusions are added to the price, and unusually low prices are flagged because a low price is not automatically good value. Deadline score depends on proposed weeks versus the client deadline, then is capped when the promise is not supported by capacity or by the reference duration. Faster delivery is not scored as better quality. This PDF contains 8 source documents in total.

3. EVA-002: EVA-002 Budget Compatibility Methodology

Source document ID: EVA-002 | Data status: Factual methodology (illustrative default parameters) with hypothetical worked examples

Purpose and scope: define how a proposal price is compared with the client's budget, separating a preferred budget from a hard limit and adjusting for scope exclusions. Live prices and budgets come from the relational database, not from PDFs.

EVA-002 executive summary

Budget score is 100 up to the client's preferred maximum, falls linearly to 50 at the hard limit, and the proposal becomes ineligible above the hard limit. Documented exclusions are added to the price, and unusually low prices are flagged because a low price is not automatically good value.

EVA-002 - Definitions

- Preferred maximum: the budget the client would like to stay within; a soft preference that can be traded off.
- Hard budget limit: the maximum the client can pay; a hard constraint.

- Adjusted price = proposed price + estimated cost of documented exclusions that the client requires (for example testing or deployment).

EVA-002 - Budget scoring rules

Condition on adjusted price P	Budget score
P <= preferred maximum	100 (capped at 80 and flagged if P < 60% of preferred maximum)
preferred < P <= hard limit	100 - 50 x (P - preferred) / (hard - preferred)
P > hard limit	0 and status INELIGIBLE_HARD_CONSTRAINT

Flag: upfront payment above 50 percent of price. Milestone structure does not change the score but is shown as a risk or protective factor.

EVA-002 - Worked numerical examples (hypothetical)

Hypothetical client: preferred maximum USD 9,000, hard limit USD 11,000. All prices are hypothetical and illustrative.

Case	Price	Excluded scope cost	Adjusted price	Score	Ineligible	Flags
A	8,000	0	8,000	100.0	No	none
B	9,800	0	9,800	80.0	No	none
C	10,500	0	10,500	62.5	No	none
D	11,500	0	11,500	0.0	Yes	Adjusted price exceeds the hard budget limit
E	4,000	0	4,000	80.0	No	Price is below 60% of the preferred maximum; verify scope before treating as value
F	6,000	3,500	9,500	87.5	No	none
G	9,000	0	9,000	100.0	No	Upfront payment above 50% of price

Case B calculation: 100 - 50 x (9,800 - 9,000) / (11,000 - 9,000) = 100 - 50 x 0.4 = 80. Case C: 100 - 50 x 0.75 = 62.5. Case F: price 6,000 plus an exclusion of 3,500 (for example testing and deployment priced by the estimation guides) gives an adjusted price of 9,500: 100 - 50 x 0.25 = 87.5. Case E illustrates the low-price flag: 4,000 is below 60 percent of 9,000 (5,400), so the score is capped at 80 and the explanation asks the client to verify scope.

EVA-002 - How scope, exclusions and uncertainty affect comparisons

- Compare like with like: add the estimated cost of required items a proposal excludes, citing the estimation guide used (EST-001 to EST-004).
- Fixed-price versus time-and-materials: for time-and-materials proposals, use the stated maximum or the estimate range; show both and the assumption.
- Currency: convert only with a stated rate and date.
- Uncertainty: if scope cannot be compared, mark the budget comparison 'low confidence' instead of guessing.

EVA-002 - Lowest bid is not automatically best value

The lowest price can reflect excluded scope, inexperience or misunderstood requirements. The method never gives extra credit for being cheaper than the preferred maximum, and flags prices far below it.

EVA-002 - Mandatory constraint versus preference

A hard limit makes the proposal ineligible regardless of weighted score. A preferred maximum only reduces the score. The client interface should ask the client to mark which budget value is a hard limit.

EVA-002 - Summary of key findings

- Budget score is flat to the preferred maximum and declines to the hard limit.

- Above the hard limit the proposal is ineligible.
- Exclusions are priced before comparison; very low bids are flagged, not rewarded.

EVA-002 - Keywords and alternative terminology

budget compatibility; budget score; hard budget limit; preferred budget; price comparison; scope exclusions; lowest bid; milestone payment; upfront payment; adjusted price

4. EVA-003: EVA-003 Deadline Compatibility Methodology

Source document ID: EVA-003 | Data status: Factual methodology (illustrative default parameters) with hypothetical worked examples

Purpose and scope: define how a proposed duration is compared with the client's deadline and how feasibility is checked against scope, dependencies, testing and stated availability.

EVA-003 executive summary

Deadline score depends on proposed weeks versus the client deadline, then is capped when the promise is not supported by capacity or by the reference duration. Faster delivery is not scored as better quality.

EVA-003 - Inputs

- Client deadline D in weeks and its type: hard (cannot be exceeded) or soft (can be traded off).
- Reference duration for the scope, taken from the estimation guides (illustrative).
- Estimated effort in hours.
- Proposed duration T in weeks and committed hours per week.
- Stated availability of the freelancer (database value).

EVA-003 - Scoring rules

Condition	Result
T <= D	Base score 100
Soft deadline and D < T <= 1.25 x D	100 - 50 x (T - D) / (0.25 x D)
Soft deadline and T > 1.25 x D	0 and flag
Hard deadline and T > D	0 and INELIGIBLE_HARD_CONSTRAINT
T < 0.6 x reference duration	Cap score at 70; flag unsupported fast delivery
Committed hours x T < 0.8 x effort	Cap score at 60; flag capacity risk
Committed hours above stated availability	Flag availability conflict

EVA-003 - Worked numerical examples (hypothetical)

Hypothetical job: soft deadline D = 8 weeks, reference duration 10 weeks, effort 240 hours. Evaluated freelancer: FRE-005 (stated availability up to 25 hours per week).

Case	Weeks T	Hours per week	Capacity (h)	Score	Flags
A	8	25	200	100.0	none
B	9	25	225	75.0	none
C	4	25	100	60.0	Duration is below 60% of the reference duration; fast delivery is not supported by evidence; Committed capacity (100 h) is below 80% of estimated effort (240 h)
D	11	25	275	0.0	Proposed duration is more than 25% beyond the soft deadline

Case	Weeks T	Hours per week	Capacity (h)	Score	Flags
E	6	20	120	60.0	Committed capacity (120 h) is below 80% of estimated effort (240 h)

Case A: T = D and capacity 200 h is at least 192 h (80 percent of 240), score 100. Case B: 9 weeks is 1 week late: 100 - 50 x 1 / 2 = 75. Case C: 4 weeks is below 6 weeks (60 percent of reference) and capacity 100 h is below 192 h, so both caps apply and the lower cap 60 is used. Case D: 11 weeks exceeds 10 weeks (1.25 x D), score 0. Case E: 20 hours per week x 6 weeks = 120 h gives capacity risk, and 6 weeks below the reference threshold exactly equals 6 so only the capacity cap applies.

Hard deadline variant: the same 9-week promise with a hard deadline of 8 weeks gives score 0.0 and status INELIGIBLE_HARD_CONSTRAINT.

EVA-003 - Considering scope, dependencies and testing

- If the proposal omits testing or deployment time, add an estimate (EST-001 to EST-004) before judging feasibility.
- Client-side dependencies (approvals, content, API keys) that can delay work should be listed as shared risks.
- Third-party processes (store review, security review) are outside freelancer control and should be flagged, not penalized as freelancer lateness.

EVA-003 - Faster delivery is not better quality

The score is 100 for any on-time duration; there is no bonus for being earlier than the deadline. Very fast delivery is treated as a risk signal when unsupported by capacity.

EVA-003 - Using delivery history

Delivery records (QUA-005) may add a flag, such as 'two of three similar projects ran late', but do not change the score by themselves because scope changes and dependencies explain many delays.

EVA-003 - Uncertainty handling

If effort or reference duration is unknown, the feasibility caps are not applied and the explanation states that feasibility could not be checked.

EVA-003 - Summary of key findings

- Soft deadlines decline linearly and hard deadlines make late proposals ineligible.
- Capacity and reference-duration checks cap unsupported promises.
- Early delivery earns no extra score.

EVA-003 - Keywords and alternative terminology

deadline compatibility; deadline score; feasibility; capacity; reference duration; hard deadline; soft deadline; unrealistic delivery; availability; delivery time

5. EST-001: EST-001 Web Project Estimation Guide

Source document ID: EST-001 | Data status: Illustrative estimates and factual estimation guidance (numbers are illustrative, not market prices)

Purpose and scope: explain how to estimate effort, duration and budget for web applications built with a front end, API and relational database, and how to check a freelancer proposal against a reasonable range.

EST-001 executive summary

Web estimates are built from a work breakdown structure (WBS), complexity factors, testing and deployment effort, and an uncertainty range. All numbers in this document are illustrative; they show method, not market prices.

EST-001 - Estimation method: work breakdown structure

A WBS (work breakdown structure) divides a project into work packages that can be estimated separately: front end, back end, database, integration, testing, deployment and documentation. Three-point estimation gives optimistic (O), most likely (M) and pessimistic (P) effort, with expected effort E = (O + 4M + P) / 6.

Assumption	Value (illustrative)
Estimate version and date	v1.0, 2026-10-14
Currency	USD
Scope	Customer ordering portal: 4 front-end modules, 3 API services, 12 tables, staging deployment
Team size	1 full-stack freelancer
Complexity	Medium
Blended rate used only for the example	USD 30 per hour; real rates vary by freelancer, region and seniority
Productive hours per week for one freelancer	20 to 30 hours depending on availability

Work package	O (h)	M (h)	P (h)	Expected (h)
Requirements clarification and design	16	24	40	25.3
Frontend (Angular, 4 modules)	80	110	160	113.3
Backend (Spring Boot, 3 services)	70	95	140	98.3
Database schema and migrations	16	24	36	24.7
Integration (payment sandbox, email)	12	20	36	21.3
Testing (unit, integration, defect fixing)	40	60	100	63.3
Deployment and CI/CD (staging)	12	20	32	20.7
Documentation and handover	8	12	20	12.7
Total	254	365	564	379.6

Illustrative budget: 380 expected hours x USD 30 = USD 11,400, before contingency. With a 15 percent contingency the example budget is about USD 13,110. A different freelancer, region or scope changes these numbers.

EST-001 - Complexity factors for web projects

Factor	Effect on effort (illustrative)
Number of distinct user roles	Each extra role adds authorization rules and test cases (+5 to 10 percent).
Third-party integrations	Payment, email and identity providers add dependency risk (+10 to 20 percent).
Non-functional targets (performance, accessibility)	Measured targets add tuning and audit time (+10 percent).
Data migration from legacy systems	Often underestimated (+15 to 30 percent).
Requirement stability	Unstable requirements raise rework; see EST-006.

EST-001 - Testing, deployment and documentation effort

Testing typically consumes 15 to 25 percent of total effort in the illustrative model. A proposal that states 'testing excluded' must be adjusted by adding an estimate for that work before comparing prices (EVA-002).

Deployment includes environment setup, pipeline configuration and smoke tests. Documentation includes API documentation and a runbook.

EST-001 - Team size and individual capacity

Effort in hours is not duration. Duration = effort / (weekly hours x number of people), adjusted for coordination overhead. Example: 380 hours at 20 hours per week by one person is 19 weeks; with 30 hours per week it is about 13 weeks. Adding people shortens duration only when work can be parallelized; coordination overhead grows with team size.

EST-001 - Dependencies and external services

Dependencies include client content, API keys, design assets, third-party sandbox availability and approval turnaround. Each unresolved dependency should be recorded as an assumption with an owner and date.

EST-001 - Estimation uncertainty and contingency

The pessimistic total (564 h) is 48 percent above the most likely total (365 h). A contingency of 10 to 20 percent is common for medium-complexity projects with well-understood technology; higher values suit unfamiliar technology. Uncertainty should be stated as a range, not hidden in a single number.

EST-001 - Evaluating proposals against estimates

The lowest bid is not automatically the best value. A bid far below the reference estimate may exclude testing, deployment or documentation, may assume a smaller scope, or may reflect inexperience. The evaluation must compare like with like by adjusting for documented exclusions (see EVA-002).

A short delivery promise is not necessarily credible. A duration below the reference duration, or one that requires more weekly hours than the freelancer states as available, is a risk signal and not evidence of speed skill (see EVA-003).

Mandatory client constraints (hard budget limit, hard deadline, mandatory technology) are separated from preferences (target budget, preferred start date, optional technologies) that can be traded off.

Evidence rule: an estimate in a proposal should list scope inclusions, exclusions, assumptions and milestones. Missing breakdowns are a missing-information signal, not proof of a bad proposal.

EST-001 - Summary of key findings

- Estimates are ranges built from a WBS, not single numbers.
- Effort and duration differ; capacity links them.
- Exclusions must be priced before comparing bids.
- All figures here are illustrative.

EST-001 - Keywords and alternative terminology

web estimation; WBS; work breakdown structure; three-point estimate; PERT; effort; contingency; Angular; Spring Boot; PostgreSQL; budget calculation; complexity factors; web project cost

6. EST-002: EST-002 Mobile Project Estimation Guide

Source document ID: EST-002 | Data status: Illustrative estimates and factual estimation guidance (numbers are illustrative, not market prices)

Purpose and scope: explain estimation for cross-platform mobile applications, including platform-specific work, store release and offline behaviour.

EST-002 executive summary

Mobile estimates need explicit lines for platform differences, device testing and store submission. Offline-first features and notifications add integration and test effort that simple screen counts do not capture.

EST-002 - Estimation method and assumptions

Assumption	Value (illustrative)
Estimate version and date	v1.0, 2026-10-14
Currency	USD
Scope	Fitness booking app: 12 screens, REST API consumption, push notifications, offline read access, Android and iOS builds
Team size	1 Flutter developer plus an existing backend
Complexity	Medium
Blended rate used only for the example	USD 30 per hour; real rates vary by freelancer, region and seniority
Productive hours per week for one freelancer	20 to 30 hours depending on availability

Work package	Expected (h, illustrative)	Notes
UI screens (12)	110	About 9 hours per screen including states
State management and API layer	50	Repositories and error handling
Offline storage and sync	45	Read-only cache is cheaper than two-way sync
Push notifications	20	Setup per platform
Testing (unit, widget, device)	70	Device matrix drives cost
Store release (Android and iOS)	30	Signing, review feedback cycles
Documentation and handover	15	
Total	340	About 17 weeks at 20 h per week

EST-002 - Complexity factors for mobile

- Two-way offline sync with conflict handling can add 30 to 60 percent to the data layer effort (PRJ-006 shipped a simple strategy and left merge logic open).
- Each additional platform target adds testing and release effort even with a shared Flutter codebase.
- Background tasks, maps, camera and payments each add platform permissions and review risk.
- Store review is outside the freelancer's control and should be a stated dependency.

EST-002 - Testing and device coverage

Device matrix: low-end Android, current Android, one older and one current iOS version. Performance profiling on a low-end device is separate work. A proposal that omits iOS testing must not be assumed to include iOS release.

EST-002 - Dependencies

Backend API readiness, design assets, developer accounts for stores, push notification credentials and legal text for store listings.

EST-002 - Deadline feasibility

340 hours at 28 hours per week is about 12 weeks. A promise of 5 weeks would require about 68 hours per week from one person, which is infeasible. Feasibility checks should compare required hours with stated availability (EVA-003).

EST-002 - Evaluating proposals

A mobile proposal that omits iOS testing or store release is not comparable to one that includes them; add the missing effort before comparing price, and treat a very short mobile duration as a capacity risk. General principles on lowest bids, short promises and mandatory versus optional constraints are defined in EST-001.

EST-002 - Summary of key findings

- Platform release and device testing need explicit estimates.
- Two-way sync is a major cost driver.
- A short promise must match stated weekly capacity.

EST-002 - Keywords and alternative terminology

mobile estimation; Flutter; app store release; device matrix; offline sync; push notifications; mobile budget; cross-platform estimate

7. EST-003: EST-003 AI Project Estimation Guide

Source document ID: EST-003 | Data status: Illustrative estimates and factual estimation guidance (numbers are illustrative, not market prices)

Purpose and scope: explain why AI and machine learning projects have higher estimation uncertainty and how to structure estimates for RAG assistants and recommenders.

EST-003 executive summary

AI projects depend on data quality and iterative experimentation. Estimates should separate data preparation, modelling or retrieval design, evaluation, integration and deployment, and should state which accuracy targets are not guaranteed.

EST-003 - Estimation method and assumptions

Assumption	Value (illustrative)
Estimate version and date	v1.0, 2026-10-14
Currency	USD
Scope	RAG assistant over 1,000 documents with citations, admin API and evaluation set
Team size	1 AI engineer
Complexity	High
Blended rate used only for the example	USD 30 per hour; real rates vary by freelancer, region and seniority
Productive hours per week for one freelancer	20 to 30 hours depending on availability

Work package	Expected (h, illustrative)	Notes
Data inventory and cleaning	60	Often the largest uncertainty
Chunking, embedding and indexing	50	Section-aware chunking for tables
Hybrid retrieval and metadata filters	55	
Answer generation with citations	45	Prompting and refusal rules
Evaluation set and metrics	55	At least 50 questions with expected sources
API and integration	50	
Deployment and monitoring	40	
Documentation	15	
Total	370	Plus 20 to 30 percent experiment contingency

EST-003 - Complexity factors for AI

- Data quality and volume (scanned PDFs, tables, versions).
- Required accuracy and the cost of wrong answers.

- Need for citations and traceability.
- Cold-start and sparsity problems for recommenders (PRJ-003).
- Security and privacy constraints on data.

EST-003 - Evaluation effort and accuracy claims

A proposal that guarantees a specific accuracy (for example 95 percent) before seeing the data is making an unsupported claim. A credible proposal describes the evaluation protocol, metrics such as Recall@K and the baseline it will beat. Evaluation effort is typically 15 percent of total effort in the illustrative model.

EST-003 - Dependencies and external services

Embedding and language model providers, API quotas and cost per request, document access, labelled data and subject-matter experts for the evaluation set.

EST-003 - Uncertainty and contingency

Use a larger contingency (20 to 30 percent) or time-boxed experiments. Define a stop condition: if the baseline is not beaten after a fixed experiment budget, report the finding rather than continue indefinitely.

EST-003 - Evaluating proposals

An AI proposal that guarantees accuracy, or is priced far below the reference, without describing data work and evaluation is not comparable; add evaluation effort before comparing. General principles on lowest bids, short promises and mandatory versus optional constraints are defined in EST-001.

EST-003 - Summary of key findings

- AI estimates carry higher uncertainty and need explicit evaluation work.
- Guaranteed accuracy before data review is unsupported.
- Time-boxed experiments protect budget.

EST-003 - Keywords and alternative terminology

AI estimation; RAG estimate; machine learning budget; data cleaning; evaluation set; experiment contingency; recommender estimate

8. EST-004: EST-004 Cloud and DevOps Estimation Guide

Source document ID: EST-004 | Data status: Illustrative estimates and factual estimation guidance (numbers are illustrative, not market prices)

Purpose and scope: explain estimation for containerization, CI/CD, infrastructure as code and Kubernetes migrations.

EST-004 executive summary

Cloud migration estimates depend on the number of services, state handling and environments. Staging success and production cut-over are separate work packages and must be estimated separately.

EST-004 - Estimation method and assumptions

Assumption	Value (illustrative)
Estimate version and date	v1.0, 2026-10-14
Currency	USD
Scope	Migrate 5 services to containers, build pipelines, provision staging and production, add monitoring
Team size	1 DevOps engineer
Complexity	Medium
Blended rate used only for the example	USD 30 per hour; real rates vary by freelancer, region and seniority
Productive hours per week for one freelancer	20 to 30 hours depending on availability

Work package	Expected (h, illustrative)	Notes
Service assessment and plan	20	Identify stateful services
Containerization (5 services)	40	About 8 hours per service
Terraform modules (network, compute)	50	
CI/CD pipelines	40	
Staging Kubernetes cluster	45	
Production cut-over and rollback rehearsal	40	Often omitted from low bids
Monitoring and alerts	25	
Documentation and runbooks	20	
Total	280	

EST-004 - Complexity factors

- Stateful services and databases.
- Compliance and access controls.
- Number of environments.
- Legacy configuration without documentation.
- Zero-downtime requirements.

EST-004 - Cloud running costs versus project cost

Project cost (labor) is distinct from cloud running cost (compute, storage, network). A proposal must state which it includes. Running-cost estimates need usage assumptions and should be given as ranges.

EST-004 - Dependencies

Cloud account access, DNS ownership, security approvals, application team availability for testing and change windows.

EST-004 - Deadline feasibility and risks

Production cut-over depends on application readiness. A hard deadline that leaves no time for rehearsal is a risk. In PRJ-005 production cut-over was deferred because a stateful service did not tolerate restarts.

EST-004 - Evaluating proposals

A cloud proposal that excludes production cut-over or rollback rehearsal is not comparable to one that includes them; add those packages before comparing, and flag hard deadlines that leave no rehearsal time. General principles on lowest bids, short promises and mandatory versus optional constraints are defined in EST-001.

EST-004 - Summary of key findings

- Staging and production cut-over are separate packages.
- Labor cost and cloud running cost must not be mixed.
- Rollback rehearsal is a required line item.

EST-004 - Keywords and alternative terminology

cloud estimation; DevOps estimate; Kubernetes migration cost; CI/CD setup; Terraform; cut-over; rollback; cloud cost

9. EST-005: EST-005 Project Deadline Risk Guide

Source document ID: EST-005 | Data status: Illustrative estimates and factual estimation guidance (numbers are illustrative, not market prices)

Purpose and scope: define how to judge whether a promised delivery date is feasible and which signals indicate deadline risk.

EST-005 executive summary

Deadline risk grows when required effort exceeds stated capacity, when dependencies are unresolved, when testing time is missing and when similar past projects ran late. A risk signal is not proof of failure.

EST-005 - Feasibility calculation

Required weeks = estimated effort hours / committed hours per week. Capacity in hours = committed hours per week x proposed weeks. Example (illustrative): effort 300 h, commitment 20 h per week, proposed 8 weeks gives capacity 160 h, which is 53 percent of the effort; the promise is infeasible unless scope or team changes.

Rule used in this knowledge base (illustrative): flag a capacity risk when capacity is below 80 percent of estimated effort; flag unsupported fast delivery when the duration is below 60 percent of the reference duration for the scope.

EST-005 - Risk indicators

Indicator	Meaning	Treat as
Capacity below 80% of effort	Not enough hours at stated availability	Risk signal
Duration below 60% of reference	Faster than typical for scope	Risk signal; ask for plan
No testing time	Quality risk	Missing information
Unresolved dependency	Client or third-party input pending	Shared risk
Past late milestones on similar work	Documented history	Evidence-based risk

EST-005 - Historical delivery evidence

In the synthetic dataset PRJ-002 finished 6 weeks late (20 planned, 26 actual), PRJ-006 three weeks late and PRJ-005 two weeks late. Lateness has to be interpreted with scope change records (EST-006) before attributing it to a freelancer.

EST-005 - Buffers and contingency planning

Add schedule buffer of 10 to 20 percent for medium projects. Place the buffer before external milestones. Use milestone checkpoints with demonstrable deliverables.

EST-005 - Hard and soft deadlines

A hard deadline (for example a legal date or event) makes later delivery ineligible. A soft deadline allows trade-offs; the penalty for lateness should be graduated (EVA-003).

EST-005 - What not to conclude

A short delivery promise without capacity support is a risk signal (see EST-001 and EVA-003). A single late project does not prove an unreliable freelancer; look at the number of records, scope changes and client-caused delays.

EST-005 - Summary of key findings

- Compare required hours with committed capacity.
- Fast promises need supporting plans.
- Late history needs context before it becomes a risk signal.

EST-005 - Keywords and alternative terminology

deadline risk; schedule feasibility; capacity; buffer; contingency; unrealistic deadline; late delivery; hard deadline; soft deadline

10. EST-006: EST-006 Scope Change Management Guide

Source document ID: EST-006 | Data status: Illustrative estimates and factual estimation guidance (numbers are illustrative, not market prices)

Purpose and scope: explain how scope changes affect cost, schedule and risk, and how change control and client approval should work.

EST-006 executive summary

Scope change is a normal part of projects, but uncontrolled change causes budget overrun and delay. A change-control process records the request, estimates impact, obtains approval and updates the baseline.

EST-006 - Types of scope change

- Client-requested additions (new feature).
- Clarifications that reveal hidden complexity.
- Technical discoveries (legacy limitation).
- Regulatory or third-party changes.

EST-006 - Change control process

Step	Content
1 Request	Written description, requester, reason
2 Impact estimate	Effort, cost, schedule, risk, dependencies
3 Approval	Client approves cost and date change in writing
4 Baseline update	Scope, milestones and budget updated
5 Record	Change log kept for later review

EST-006 - Impact example (illustrative)

A client of a USD 9,000 project requests a new reporting module estimated at 40 hours (USD 1,200 at USD 30 per hour, illustrative). If approved, the budget becomes USD 10,200 and, at 20 hours per week, the schedule extends by 2 weeks unless other scope is removed.

EST-006 - Effect on proposal comparison

Proposals should state how change requests are priced. A low initial price with expensive change terms can cost more overall. Proposals that exclude items the client lists as mandatory must be adjusted (EVA-002).

EST-006 - Contingency and approvals

Contingency reserves are for uncertainty inside the agreed scope; they are not a substitute for approved scope changes. Approval must come from the person authorized by the client.

EST-006 - Interpreting delays and overruns

In PRJ-002 the escrow requirement changed during the project, which contributed to the six-week delay. Records that show client-driven change must not be counted against the freelancer as unreliability without that context (QUA-005).

EST-006 - Evaluating proposals

A proposal that leaves change-request pricing unclear is hard to compare; treat this as missing information, not a negative signal. General principles on lowest bids, short promises and mandatory versus optional constraints are defined in EST-001.

EST-006 - Summary of key findings

- Scope change needs written impact estimates and approval.
- Contingency is not a scope-change fund.
- Delay records need scope-change context.

EST-006 - Keywords and alternative terminology

scope change; change control; change request; scope creep; baseline; client approval; budget overrun; contingency

11. Summary of key findings

- EVA-002: Budget score is flat to the preferred maximum and declines to the hard limit.
- EVA-003: Soft deadlines decline linearly and hard deadlines make late proposals ineligible.
- EST-001: Estimates are ranges built from a WBS, not single numbers.
- EST-002: Platform release and device testing need explicit estimates.
- EST-003: AI estimates carry higher uncertainty and need explicit evaluation work.
- EST-004: Staging and production cut-over are separate packages.
- EST-005: Compare required hours with committed capacity.
- EST-006: Scope change needs written impact estimates and approval.

12. Keywords and alternative terminology

budget compatibility; budget score; hard budget limit; preferred budget; price comparison; scope exclusions; lowest bid; milestone payment; upfront payment; adjusted price; deadline compatibility; deadline score; feasibility; capacity; reference duration; hard deadline; soft deadline; unrealistic delivery; availability; delivery time; web estimation; WBS; work breakdown structure; three-point estimate; PERT; effort; contingency; Angular; Spring Boot; PostgreSQL; budget calculation; complexity factors; web project cost; mobile estimation; Flutter; app store release; device matrix; offline sync; push notifications; mobile budget; cross-platform estimate; AI estimation; RAG estimate; machine learning budget; data cleaning; evaluation set; experiment contingency; recommender estimate; cloud estimation; DevOps estimate; Kubernetes migration cost; CI/CD setup; Terraform; cut-over; rollback; cloud cost; deadline risk; schedule feasibility; buffer; unrealistic deadline; late delivery; scope change; change control; change request; scope creep; baseline; client approval; budget overrun